

# THE ALTCOIN BEAR MARKET GUIDE

## 2026 EDITION

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Which Altcoins Are Actually Worth Buying  
When Everyone Else Is Panic Selling?

**3 Full Cycles**

of data analyzed

**100 Altcoins**

ranked by tier

**15 Million+**

tokens competing for your \$

*Based on real data from the 2015, 2018, and 2022 bear market bottoms.  
Not vibes. Not narratives. History.*

# THE PROBLEM: ALTCOIN DILUTION

Everyone's waiting for altseason. The moment Bitcoin consolidates and money rotates into alts, sending everything 10-50x. That era is over.

Here's why:

2017 BULL MARKET

**~1,300**

total tokens

2021 BULL MARKET

**~10,000**

total tokens

2026 TODAY

**15M+**

total tokens

The money doesn't multiply. It dilutes. Every new memecoin, every new L2, every new 'ETH killer' is another bucket the same liquidity has to fill.

In 2017 there were ~1,300 tokens competing for capital.  
Today there are over 15 million. That's a 10,000x increase in dilution.

Institutional money flows into BTC and ETH ETFs, not your favorite low-cap. The capital that used to rotate down the risk curve now exits into stablecoins or traditional markets entirely.

So the question isn't 'when is altseason?' The question is:

**"Which altcoins are actually worth buying in a bear market?"**

To answer this, I analyzed every coin in the top 100 across THREE bear market bottoms: 2015, 2018, and 2022. Then I tracked what happened by each cycle's peak.

The results were identical across all three. Let me show you.

## 3 CYCLES. SAME PATTERN.

What \$25,000 invested equally in each tier returned at each cycle's peak

| TIER         | 2018-2021 | 2022-2025 |
|--------------|-----------|-----------|
| TOP 25       | +1,846%   | +199%     |
| RANKS 26-50  | +435%     | +91%      |
| RANKS 51-75  | +254%     | -5%       |
| RANKS 76-100 | +351%     | -27%      |

### NOTE ON THE 2015 CYCLE

Accurate tier-by-tier data for the 2015-2017 cycle was not available. However, the top-ranked coins at the 2015 bottom (BTC, ETH, LTC, XRP) still dominated returns. Full data on page 7.

### KEY INSIGHT

The Top 25 outperformed EVERY other tier in BOTH tracked cycles.

In 2022-2025 (the 'no altseason' cycle), the bottom 50 coins LOST money even during a bull run. The dilution effect is accelerating.

The pattern is undeniable: higher rank = higher returns, lower risk.  
And it's getting worse for low-cap coins, not better.

## THE \$25K EXPERIMENT (2018-2021)

What if you invested \$25K equally across each tier at the 2018 bear bottom?

| TIER     | INVESTED | PROFIT    | RETURN  | BUSTS |
|----------|----------|-----------|---------|-------|
| TOP 10   | \$25,000 | \$160,806 | +1,608% | 0     |
| TOP 25   | \$25,000 | \$461,570 | +1,846% | 0     |
| 26 - 50  | \$25,000 | \$108,750 | +435%   | 0     |
| 51 - 75  | \$25,000 | \$63,500  | +254%   | 7     |
| 76 - 100 | \$25,000 | \$87,750  | +351%   | 9     |

## THE SAME TEST (2022-2025)

The 'no altseason' bull run confirmed the pattern got WORSE

| TIER         | RETURN | STATUS     |
|--------------|--------|------------|
| TOP 25       | +199%  | Profitable |
| RANKS 26-50  | +91%   | Profitable |
| RANKS 51-75  | -5%    | LOST MONEY |
| RANKS 76-100 | -27%   | LOST MONEY |

### THE DILUTION EFFECT IS ACCELERATING

In 2018-2021, even ranks 76-100 averaged +351%. By 2022-2025, they averaged -27%.  
More tokens = less money per coin = lower-ranked alts can't recover anymore.

# THE TOP 25: WHERE THE MONEY IS

\$1,000 invested at the 2018 bear bottom | Measured at the 2021 peak

| COIN             | RANK (2018) | RETURN   | \$1K BECAME |
|------------------|-------------|----------|-------------|
| Binance Coin     | #13         | +12,729% | \$127,296   |
| Dogecoin         | #20         | +11,078% | \$110,782   |
| Cardano          | #10         | +6,133%  | \$61,333    |
| Ethereum         | #3          | +5,176%  | \$51,760    |
| VeChain          | #24         | +2,093%  | \$20,936    |
| Bitcoin          | #1          | +1,942%  | \$19,424    |
| Nexo             | #71*        | +1,397%  | \$13,971    |
| Waves            | #21         | +1,077%  | \$10,779    |
| Tezos            | #22         | +1,007%  | \$10,075    |
| Ethereum Classic | #16         | +958%    | \$9,584     |
| Tron             | #9          | +900%    | \$9,000     |
| Litecoin         | #6          | +805%    | \$8,055     |
| OmiseGO          | #25         | +704%    | \$7,044     |
| Maker            | #19         | +618%    | \$6,188     |
| Bitcoin Gold     | #23         | +574%    | \$5,743     |
| Neo              | #17         | +471%    | \$4,710     |
| Bitcoin Cash     | #7          | +457%    | \$4,575     |
| Monero           | #11         | +421%    | \$4,219     |
| IOTA             | #12         | +383%    | \$3,838     |
| Basic Attention  | #26*        | +343%    | \$3,435     |
| XRP              | #2          | +250%    | \$2,500     |
| Stellar          | #4          | +175%    | \$1,750     |
| NEM              | #14         | +160%    | \$1,602     |
| EOS              | #5          | +131%    | \$1,317     |
| Bitcoin SV       | #8          | +108%    | \$1,089     |

**25 out of 25 coins were profitable. ZERO busts.**

Even the worst performer (Bitcoin SV at +108%) still doubled your money.

# THE BUST ZONE: RANKS 51-100

These coins LOST money from the 2018 bottom to the 2021 peak

| COIN             | RANK (2018) | RETURN | LOST PER \$1K |
|------------------|-------------|--------|---------------|
| Arbitrage        | #100        | -100%  | -\$1,000      |
| Dentacoin        | #75         | -97%   | -\$977        |
| GXChain          | #91         | -92%   | -\$922        |
| Bitcoin Private  | #68         | -92%   | -\$920        |
| Revain           | #47         | -90%   | -\$903        |
| Qash             | #48         | -81%   | -\$820        |
| Factom           | #43         | -80%   | -\$801        |
| MobileGo         | #79         | -78%   | -\$781        |
| Single Collat... | #56         | -75%   | -\$753        |
| Aeternity        | #42         | -73%   | -\$733        |
| Aurora           | #41         | -58%   | -\$588        |
| Bytecoin         | #35         | -56%   | -\$560        |
| MOAC             | #94         | -53%   | -\$534        |
| TenX             | #57         | -52%   | -\$526        |
| ODEM             | #77         | -51%   | -\$517        |
| Electroneum      | #58         | -51%   | -\$513        |
| Waltonchain      | #72         | -51%   | -\$511        |
| Mixin            | #84         | -43%   | -\$431        |
| QuarkChain       | #76         | -36%   | -\$368        |
| Mithril          | #83         | -36%   | -\$363        |
| Aion             | #88         | -34%   | -\$343        |
| Polymath         | #70         | -22%   | -\$220        |
| Ontology         | #30         | -8%    | -\$86         |

## 23 OUT OF 100 COINS LOST MONEY

Even buying at the absolute bear market bottom couldn't save these coins.

16 of the 23 busts came from ranks 51-100. Lower rank = higher death rate.

And in the 2022-2025 cycle? Ranks 51-100 went negative as a group.

# CYCLE 1: THE 2015 BEAR BOTTOM

\$1,000 invested Aug 23, 2015 | Measured at Dec 17, 2017 peak

| COIN      | PRICE (2015) | PRICE (2017) | RETURN    | \$1K BECAME |
|-----------|--------------|--------------|-----------|-------------|
| Ethereum  | \$1.24       | \$715.15     | +576,600% | \$5.7M      |
| Dash      | \$3.22       | \$1,138      | +353,800% | \$3.5M      |
| Litecoin  | \$3.05       | \$319.70     | +104,800% | \$1.0M      |
| Bitshares | \$0.003      | \$0.30       | +97,400%  | \$974K      |
| XRP       | \$0.01       | \$0.72       | +86,600%  | \$866K      |
| Bitcoin   | \$228.22     | \$19,192     | +83,600%  | \$836K      |
| Stellar   | \$0.003      | \$0.21       | +83,400%  | \$834K      |
| Dogecoin  | \$0.0001     | \$0.003      | +28,000%  | \$280K      |
| Bytecoin  | < \$0.01     | < \$0.01     | +14,500%  | \$145K      |
| Banx      | < \$0.01     | \$0.01       | +6,400%   | \$64K       |

## SAME PATTERN. THREE CYCLES. NO EXCEPTIONS.

Top-ranked coins at the bear bottom delivered the largest gains in every cycle.

Multi-cycle survivors: BTC, ETH, LTC, XRP, DOGE, XLM.

Survival + high rank = the highest probability trade in crypto.

Across 2015, 2018, and 2022 bear bottoms, the pattern is identical:  
the higher the market cap, the higher the returns and the lower the risk.

# YOUR BEAR MARKET ALTCOIN PLAYBOOK

5 rules backed by 3 cycles of data

1

## STICK TO THE TOP 25 BY MARKET CAP

The top 25 had ZERO busts across both tracked cycles (2018 and 2022). Every single coin was profitable. The further down the rankings, the higher the chance of total loss.

2

## LOOK FOR MULTI-CYCLE SURVIVORS

BTC, ETH, LTC, XRP, DOGE, and XLM survived all three bear markets and delivered massive gains each time. Coins that survive one bear market are more likely to survive the next.

3

## AVOID COINS RANKED 51-100

In 2018-2021, 32% of coins ranked 51-100 went bust. In 2022-2025, the entire group averaged NEGATIVE returns. The risk-reward doesn't justify it.

4

## WAIT FOR EXTREME FEAR

These returns were measured from the bear market bottom. You don't need to time the exact bottom, but buy when everyone else is selling. Fear & Greed below 15. Social sentiment in the gutter. That's when you accumulate.

5

## SIZE POSITIONS BY TIER

Allocate 50-60% to the top 10, 25-30% to ranks 11-25, and no more than 10-15% to ranks 26-50. Skip 51-100 entirely unless you're willing to lose it all.

**The math doesn't care about your bags.**

But if you follow the math, your bags will thank you.



# 3 CYCLES. SAME RESULT.

## THE QUESTION IS:

# WILL YOU ACT ON IT?

Most traders will read this, nod, and go back to buying low-cap coins because someone on Twitter said they'd 100x.

The ones who actually build wealth? They follow the data.

### WANT MORE?

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**Not vibes. Not narratives. History.**

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